

Manifesto in Defense of the Lives of Guardians of the World's Food Cultures

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Food on the planet is collapsing! Guardians of food cultures, who ensure that ecosystems remain alive and that food reaches the populations of the fields, waters, backlands, forests, and cities, are threatened and assassinated at the same speed as the aggression against their territories by those who cause mass destruction.

From our knowledge, remedies and delights are born; from our memories, the fight against hunger and in defense of food sovereignty is raised; from our actions: technologies, innovations, and confluences. For the city to eat, the field needs to plant, the forest needs to harvest, the water needs to be clean for the fish to be born. Indigenous peoples and local communities safeguard more than 80% of the planet's biodiversity. Without guardians, there are no seeds, no cures, no springs. Food sovereignty only exists with living cultures! It is urgent to defend those who defend food cultures!

Between armed conflicts, the financialization of nature, and the devastation of biomes, we are on the verge of mass extinction, with the loss of at least 25% of edible species and an increase of over 50% in assassinations of socio-environmental and traditional leaders in 2024.

Cultural diversity and biological diversity are inseparable! The extermination of food culture is a harbinger of the death of a people. Neither the Amazon nor the world is fed by the commodities that ensure the world record for pesticide consumption, concentration of land and income, acidification of waters, and increase in ocean temperatures, alarming rates of slave labor and human trafficking, biopiracy, precariousness of education and basic services, gentrification, deterritorialization, and the overwhelming racism and colonialism against the original food that the global north imposes on the non-white peoples of the world, mainly in Abya Yala (Latin America) and Africa.

Whoever stands up in defense of life is a target. The aim is certain: we, the indigenous, traditional, popular, and peripheral cultures, the same ones that safeguard the cultural and genetic heritage. For the heritage to exist, the people must be alive to practice their culture! And we, guardians of the world's food cultures, who raise the sky, listen to the breath of nature and plant, cultivate, manage, harvest, fish, create, and cook without pesticides, without transgenics, without agro-hydro-business, without annihilation of nature and cultures, and we denounce the violations of human rights, injustices, and environmental crimes, are being killed. It is urgent to understand: every fallen leader is less food on the table!

We live in a society that produces seeds that do not sprout, that criminalizes healthy artisanal foods, that relaxes laws on pesticides and transgenics, that causes contamination of breast milk, that made plastic cross the placenta, that transformed a child into an enemy, that kills those who feed!

We are not a threat! We are guardians of food cultures; our food does not kill by disease or by conflict. We are the living memory, the safeguard of traditional knowledge, we are body-territories, we are seed-people. Our worldview illuminates, our ancestry makes us, our spirituality guides, our hands feed and heal, our way of life regenerates the climate, our food makes the sun rest!

Thus, in this framework of global destruction of ecosystems and rights, we call on everyone to join the collective struggle and we demand from UNESCO, the United Nations, and Member States:

- The creation of a Global program of recognition, protection, and support for the lives of Guardians of the World's Food Cultures, with a budget and personnel structure for execution and implementation;
- To recognize and adapt the use of the term 'food culture' in international agreements and protocols in substitution of the use of the word 'gastronomy' as a synonym for culture, since the use of the word 'gastronomy' as a synonym for culture implies equating fast foods, ultra-processed foods, transgenic products, and other products of the food and beverage industry and agribusiness with the productions of just, culturally and socio-environmentally responsible food systems and artisanal productions of indigenous peoples and traditional and peasant communities;
- To recognize and adapt the use of the term 'food culture' in international agreements and protocols on Creative Economy in substitution of the use of the word 'gastronomy' as a synonym for culture;
- The creation of a program for the integral protection and maintenance of food cultures and their just production systems with recognition of guardians and intergenerational continuous practices;
- The recognition of traditional food cultural practices as cultural expressions to be included in programs for the safeguarding of traditional knowledge and benefit-sharing;
- The recognition of food culture as a solution to the climate, environmental, and food crisis;
- The recognition of guardians of the food cultures of the waters as inseparable from the survival of mangroves, basins, rivers, and oceans;
- Strengthening of the bioeconomy agenda proposed in the G20, with the guarantee of inclusion with specific budgetary allocation for the support and practices of guardians of food cultures;
- Immediate suspension of fossil fuel programs and strengthening of the just energy transition;
- Recognition of cultural violations as a criminal offense;
- Unwavering defense of the self-determination of peoples and their territories and non-negotiable guarantee of social participation in decision-making and negotiation tables;
- Demarcation, guarantee, consolidation, and maintenance of indigenous territories and of traditional peoples and communities and their 'maretórios' [sea territories]; in order to reaffirm the rights and Buen Vivir (sumak kawsay, a Kichwa term) of these populations over their territories and 'maretórios';
- Popular and agrarian reform;

- Creation of mechanisms for the socio-bioeconomy of Guardians;
- Recognition and inclusion of guardians with fair and equitable remuneration in public and private institutions, formal and non-formal, of teaching, research, science, and technology;
- Guarantee of the creation, implementation and execution, strengthening and expansion of public policies for the promotion, innovation, and safeguarding of food cultures and traditional knowledge associated with genetic heritage and for food security and sovereignty and the fight against hunger, vulnerability, misery, and poverty;
- Guarantee of the creation, implementation and execution, strengthening and expansion of public policies to combat and prevent socio-environmental threats and crimes, crimes against dignity and human and drug trafficking and trafficking of species;

Patrimonializing is not enough! All non-white peoples of the planet are under threat! It is urgent to guarantee the lives of Guardians of the world's food cultures!

We want our forests, seeds, peoples, youths, and children alive!

We want to live to hold up the sky!

We want to see the old sower birds land on the ancient trees and feed the fields, forests, waters, and cities of hope, culture, and peace.

To defend who defends is now!

This manifesto is supported by the Amazon Investor Coalition.

Are you a guardian of food culture? Get in touch with us and send your experience to manifestoculturaalimentar@gmail.com

Do you want to sign the manifesto? Send an email to manifestoculturaalimentar@gmail.com

Do you want to make a donation to support our actions?

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